Miss Alaineus: A Vocabulary Disaster

By Debra Frasier

None of this would have happened if it wasn't for Forest. Forest is not ***a thicket of trees.*** Forest is a boy. A sick boy. A boy sneezing and coughing all over my desk and pencils.

I caught Forest's cold and had to stay home from school on Tuesday. Tuesday is Vocabulary Day at Webster School. Follow my advice: Never get sick on Vocabulary Day.

INTRODUCTION

Remember vocabulary tests from elementary school? That's where we learned how to spell FEBRUARY (Feb-RU-ary), Wednesday (WED – NES – DAY) and TARANTULA (TARE – IN – TULA). And where we learned that there is a silent "S" in Island and it is not pronounced IS-LAND. And don't even get me started on the word spelled A-I-S-L-E. Take a walk down memory lane with me in Debra Frasier's Miss Alaineus: A Vocabulary Disaster.

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On Tuesday afternoon I called my best friend, Starr who is not a luminous celestial object seen as a point of light in the sky, but a very smart girl who listens perfectly on Vocabulary Day. She was late for baseball practice, so she spelled the first fourteen vocabulary words as fast as she could.

I had to scribble them quickly because her mom was calling her to the car.

"The last one's 'Miss Alaineus'!" Starr yelled. "I gotta go. I hope you feel better tomorrow, Sage." And she hung up the phone with a crash.

1 ***dinosaur***, 2. ***snake***, 3. ***museum***, 4. ***reptile***, 5. ***constrictor***, 6. ***herpetologist***, 7. ***fossil***, 8. ***carnivore***, 9. ***herbivore***, 10. ***nest***, 11. ***species***, 12. ***theory***, 13. ***hypothesis***, 14. ***category***, 15. ***Miss Alaineus.***

I didn't feel much better on Wednesday, so my mom called Mrs. Page, who is not ***a single side of a printed sheet of paper usually found bound in a book.*** She's my teacher, and actually Mrs. Page is a good name for her because she reads to us every day. My mom told

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her yes, I had my math problems and vocabulary words, and yes, I would get better soon.

Every week Mrs. Page gives us a list of words with a theme, like Story Writing or Musical Performance or Electricity. We're supposed to look up each word in the dictionary, but sometimes I already know the words, so I try to make the definitions sound like I looked them up.

By Thursday afternoon my head felt like it was stuffed with cotton and my throat felt swollen shut. I finished defining my vocabulary words while propped up in bed with a box of tissues on one side and a gigantic red dictionary on the other. It's hard to look up words in a huge book while you're in bed blowing your nose, so I made my own dictionary language for as many of them as I could.

13 ***hypothesis***: what you guess will happen in your science experiment

14 ***category***: a bunch of things that are alike

15 ***Miss Alaineus***:

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The last word seemed a little odd to me because I couldn't figure out what she had to do with snakes or categories or theories. Mrs. Page rarely gives us people's names on our vocabulary lists, but we have had a few that turned into words, like Louis Pasteur for ***pasteurization*** and George Washington for ***Washington, D.C.***, so I decided she must have been included for a reason.

You should know that for years I had wondered who Miss Alaineus was. When I was little I figured out that she had something to do with the kitchen, because the Miss Alaineus drawer held the spoons too big to fit anywhere else, the sharp corn holders shaped like tiny cobs, and the spaghetti spork, that weird cross between a spoon and a fork that perfectly lifts slippery spaghetti out of the bowl. I thought maybe she was an ***ancestor: an ancient relative long dead***, who left us all these odd things in the drawer.

Then just last year my mom and I were at the grocery store and it all fell into place. We were in one of those Very Big Hurries when she said, "You go get

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some of that long Italian bread and two sticks of butter. I'll get Miss Alaineus' things and meet you here at the cash register."

I found the bread and butter, and my mom came back with spaghetti sauce, a can of Parmesan cheese, a can of corn and a big green box of spaghetti with a beautiful woman on the front. She was drawn so that her hair tumbled perfectly across the box and ended in a little plastic window, making the spaghetti look just like the ends of the strands of her hair.

There she was – Miss Alaineus.

So, propped up on pillows in my bed, with a tissue in one hand and a pencil in the other, I wrote:

15 ***Miss Alaineus: the woman on green spaghetti boxes whose hair is the color of uncooked pasta and turns into spaghetti at the ends***

And then I fell asleep.

I finally got better over the weekend and felt great on Monday. I turned in my homework to Mrs. Page and sat down at my desk, glad to be back at school with

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my friends. I was even glad to see Forest at our morning circle meeting.

"First, I want to remind you of the Tenth Annual Vocabulary Parade on Friday," said Mrs. Page. "I hope you are all working on your word costumes. Second, please remember to bring your bus money and permission slips for our science museum field trip tomorrow. And third, instead of our usual Monday test, we are going to have a Vocabulary Bee today.

"Everyone line up here by the chalkboard, and I'll choose a word from our list. After I pronounce the word, please spell and define it. If you are correct, go to the end of the line. If you miss the word, please sit down at your desk and look it up in the dictionary. Write the word five times and define it once."

Starr was the first with ***museum: "M-U-S-E-U=M: a building for exhibiting objects about art or history or science"*** she said, and went to the back of the line.

Cliff, not a high, steep face of rock, but one very tall boy, answered to the word ***dinosaur: "D-I-N-O-***

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S-A-U-R: a prehistoric, extinct reptile, often huge," and he went to the back of the line.

I was tenth, and when Mrs. Page called out my word, I spelled: ***"Capital M-I-S-S, capital A-L-A-I-N-E-U-S,"*** and added, ***"the woman on green spaghetti boxes whose hair is the color of uncooked pasta and turns into spaghetti at the ends."***

There was a moment of silence in the room. I smiled at Mrs. Page. She waited to see if I would add anything else, and when I didn't, she grinned. Not smiled – ***grinned: to draw back the lips and bare the teeth, as in a very wide smile*** – and the entire class burst into one huge giggling, laughing, falling-down mass of kids. Forest was doubled over. Starr, my best friend, was laughing so hard tears came to her eyes. By now, even Mrs. Page was laughing.

Pride goeth before a fall. I was ***Sage: one who shows wisdom, experience, judgment***. Why were they laughing? "Wise-girl-with-words" my dad always called me. What had I said? I was beginning to turn red. ***Red: The color of embarrassment.***

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Finally the room quieted. Mrs. Page opened her dictionary and wrote on the chalkboard:

Miscellaneous: adj. 1) consisting of various kinds or qualities 2) a collection of unrelated objects

My jaw dropped as I looked at the spelling. My eyes bulged as I read the definition. I didn't bother to tell anyone about my mom and the spaghetti spork and the grocery store. ***Humbled: aware of my shortcomings, modest, meek***, I dragged back to my seat and wrote ***miscellaneous*** five times and defined it once. And that's when I remembered I had even drawn a picture of the spaghetti box for extra credit. I was ***devastated: wasted, ravaged. Ruined: destroyed. Finished: brought to an end.***

They called me Miss Alaineus for the rest of the day. Sometimes a person couldn't even get the words out before bending over with laughter. The day took a week to end. When I got off the bus I slumped home – **devastated, ruined, finished**.

I told my mom the whole story, from the kitchen drawer to the grocery store to the Vocabulary Bee.

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Even my own mother laughed a little at the part about the drawing for extra credit, but at least she stopped fast and said, "You know what I always say . . . There's gold in every mistake."

Gold? A bright yellow precious metal or great value?

Mistake? Something done, said, or thought in the wrong way?

"Impossible," I told her. ***Impossible: not capable of happening.***

I couldn't believe I **ever** had to go back to school. But the next day we went to the science museum, and everyone forgot all about Miss Alaineus at the snake exhibit and the dinosaur bone lab. Then the guide said, "The field of bone archaeology has been influenced by a wide and unusual array of miscellaneous discoveries around the world." The class burst out laughing, and the guide was pleased with herself for entertaining us so easily. And I ***knew: to apprehend with certainty*** that my mistake was still alive and well, and nothing like gold.

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After school I lay on my bed and stared at the wall. How could I have been so stupid?

My mom came in and said it was time to work on my costume for the Vocabulary Parade. We had finished the cape for **Capable**, but I still needed to make the lettering down the back.

"Mom," I said, "I could only be a mistake this year. **Miss Stake**."

Suddenly I sat up. I looked at my mom. She looked at me. I smiled. She smiled.

"Sweetheart," she said, "let's take another look at that cape."

It took the most courage I've ever had to walk out on that stage as ***Miss Alaineus, Queen of All Miscellaneous Things***. But when Mr. Bell read my word and definition, everyone applauded and laughed ***wildly: in a manner lacking all restraint***, and I grinned at my mom across the auditorium.

Forest came right after me. When he bowed, his ***Precipitation*** watering-can hat rained on Mr. Bell's new

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suit, and the entire audience gasped, then cheered when Mr. Bell smiled at his soggy clothes.

To my astonishment: great shock and amazement, I won a gold trophy for the Most Original Use of a Word in the Tenth Annual Vocabulary Parade.

So this time Mom was right. There was good in this mistake. . And next year I think I'm going to be . . . **Miss Sterious, Investigator of All Things Mysterious.**

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Debra Frasier
ISBN: 978-0152060534
Publisher: HMH Books for Young Readers
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2007

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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